Being "Cyber-Smart": Your College Survival Checklist

Look, we're all online 24/7—whether it's for classes, food orders, or late-night scrolling. But being tech-savvy isn't just about knowing the latest features; it's about not letting a split-second mistake ruin your week (or your bank account).

Run through this checklist and see how many boxes you've actually ticked:

- **Lock the Front Door (2FA):** Seriously, turn on Two-Factor Authentication for WhatsApp and Instagram. Using an app like Google Authenticator is better than SMS, but either one creates a massive wall that hackers hate.
- **The "Wait and Hover" Rule:** Before you tap that link in a text or email, hold down on it to see the real web address. If it looks like a mess of random letters or ends in `.xyz` instead of `.edu` or `.com`, it's a trap.
- **Stop Reusing "That One Password":** We all have that one password we use for everything. Stop! If your favorite pizza site gets hacked, they now have the key to your student portal. Use a Password Manager to do the heavy lifting for you.
- **Check Your App's "Privacy Hunger":** Does that free photo-editing app really need access to your contacts and microphone? Go into your settings and revoke permissions for anything that feels "creepy."
- **Keep Your Circle Tight:** Set your socials to "Private." If a random account with no profile pic and zero mutual friends requests you, they're likely just there to scrape your photos for identity theft.
- **The Public Wi-Fi Danger Zone:** Free Wi-Fi at the café is great, but it's a playground for hackers. Never log into your bank or student portal on public networks. Stick to your 5G or use a VPN.
- **UPI Rule #1—Receiving is Free:** This is the big one. **You NEVER need to enter your PIN to receive money.** If someone says they're "sending a refund" but asks for your PIN or a QR scan, they are trying to rob you. Period.
- **UPI Rule #2—Look at the Name:** Before you hit 'Pay' on a UPI app, look at the actual name that pops up. Scammers use names like "SBI_Customer_Care" to trick you, but the underlying ID will look suspicious. Trust your gut.

What to do if things go wrong?

If you get scammed, don't be embarrassed—it happens to the best of us. **Acting fast is the only way to get your money back.**

1. **The "SOS" Line:** Immediately call **1930**. This is the national helpline specifically for financial cyber-fraud.
2. **Report It:** File the details at **cybercrime.gov.in**. This helps the police track down the person before they hit someone else.

My Reflection: What I Learned

Researching this was a bit of a reality check for me. I always thought cybercrime was about genius hackers typing lines of green code in a dark room. I was honestly surprised to find out it's actually much simpler—and meaner. It’s mostly "Social Engineering," which is just a fancy way of saying they manipulate your emotions. Seeing how many Indian students lose their hard-earned allowance to UPI scams just because they were panicked into "verifying" something really hit home. It proved that being "good with computers" doesn't mean you're safe if you're not careful with your emotions.

The biggest change for me? I’m killing my "click-first" habit. I used to trust every "Urgent" notification from my university or bank. From now on, I’m practicing **"Zero Trust."** If I get an alert saying my account is locked, I won't click their link. I’ll close the app, open my browser, and type the website address in myself. It takes ten extra seconds, but it beats losing my digital life.